

Summary: Yanchar & Gabbitas Between Eclecticism and Orthodoxy

The Problem with Eclecticism

Yanchar and Gabbitas challenge the conventional wisdom that eclecticism offers openness and flexibility in instructional design. While eclecticism claims to allow practitioners to freely borrow from diverse theories without constraint, the authors argue it actually perpetuates hidden rigidity. Eclecticism encourages designers to combine theories at face value without examining incompatibilities or underlying assumptions. This approach ironically obscures the very design decisions it claims to liberate, as designers end up operating under unexamined assumptions while believing they're being flexible. The authors note that eclecticism results in "little or no attention need be paid to the means by which design is actually produced" (p. 385).

Conceptual Design Sense as Hidden Framework

The authors introduce "conceptual design sense" - the strategic understanding of quality instruction that includes designers' often unarticulated assumptions and values about learning, knowledge, agency, and design itself. This sense operates as what they call a "cryptothory" - a hidden framework that significantly guides design decisions regardless of which explicit theories designers claim to use. Through examples and research citations, they demonstrate that even eclectic practitioners rely on implicit frameworks when selecting which theories to combine and how to apply them. This background understanding isn't problematic in itself - it's actually necessary for design work - but becomes problematic when left unexamined and unacknowledged.

Critical Flexibility as Alternative

Critical flexibility offers a middle path between rigid theoretical orthodoxy and unfocused eclecticism. Rather than avoiding theoretical commitments or rigidly adhering to one framework, critical flexibility involves explicitly examining one's conceptual design sense, remaining open to its evolution, and strategically reformulating conceptual tools to fit coherently with developing practice. The authors describe this approach as "syncretic, rather than eclectic" (p. 392), emphasizing coherent assimilation rather than haphazard borrowing. Critical flexibility requires viewing design sense as fluid and capable of transformation through reflection, making it "the antithesis of habit" (p. 391). This approach demands continuous self-

examination and willingness to adjust assumptions based on experience and critical dialogue.

Implications for Practice and Training

The authors advocate for scholarship studying conceptual design sense in practice and for graduate training emphasizing critical reflection on evolving views of learning and instruction. They recommend exposure to diverse conceptual resources viewed as flexible tools rather than rigid prescriptions, alongside cultivation of critical examination skills. Professional activities like collegial dialogue, reading widely, and participating in workshops become crucial for facilitating the "clash of divergent views" that helps designers clarify their assumptions. This approach reframes the theory-practice divide by recognizing that practice is always already theoretical - the question is whether that theorizing remains hidden or becomes explicit and examined.

Relevance to Your Research

This article directly connects to your Freirean critical pedagogy framework and emphasis on examining power structures in education. Yanchar and Gabbitas's critique of eclecticism parallels critical pedagogy's interrogation of supposedly "neutral" practices - both reveal how claims of neutrality or flexibility can mask hidden ideological commitments. Their concept of "cryptotheory" resonates with your work on uncovering colonial thought patterns and challenging taken-for-granted educational assumptions.

The critical flexibility framework offers a methodological complement to your autoethnography work - it provides language for the reflexive examination process you're already doing when you analyze your own assumptions through a critical lens. Their emphasis on making implicit frameworks explicit, examining them through dialogue with divergent perspectives, and remaining open to transformation aligns well with decolonial approaches that center ongoing critical self-reflection rather than adherence to fixed methods. This could strengthen your theoretical justification for the reflective processes in your tech-based autoethnography project.